

How To Build Your Brand Workbook

By Caleb Ralston



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Consider reading this before going further.

Hey there. Hi — I'm grateful you downloaded this workbook. If you're here, you're probably trying to build a brand but feeling stuck. Maybe you don't know where to start, maybe your content isn't actually growing your brand, or maybe you've built something, but it's not converting the way it should.

This workbook is designed to be paired with my How to Build a Brand Course. Simply click the hyperlink to view the course, completely free.

I know your time and attention are valuable, and I don't take that lightly. That's exactly why I made this workbook. No more just watching videos and hoping something clicks — this is about taking action, driving real results, and producing a strong ROI on your time.

If you follow the course, fill out the worksheets, and review the playbooks you'll have a clear game plan to build something real.

Let's get into it.



01

Define Your Brand

Brand Journey Framework Worksheet

Objective

Building a brand isn't about guesswork—it's about intentional strategy. The Brand Journey Framework simplifies this process into four key questions that help you reverse-engineer your success. Instead of aimlessly creating content or hoping your brand takes off, this exercise ensures that every action you take aligns with your long-term vision.

By answering these four questions, you'll gain clarity on:

- The ultimate goal you're working toward
- The reputation and positioning you need to achieve it
- The actions required to reinforce that reputation
- The skills and knowledge necessary to execute effectively

This isn't just a thought exercise—it's a roadmap. Follow it, and you'll build a brand with purpose, consistency, and long-term impact.

Exercise	
What do I want to have happen?	
What do I have to be known for in order for that to happen?	
What do I have to do in order to be known for that?	
What do I have to learn in order to do those things?	

02

The Brand Story Framework

Brand Story Worksheet

Objective

Your brand story isn't just a before-and-after transformation — it's a series of intentional decisions that shape how people see you. Great brands aren't built on a single moment — they're built on consistency, distinction, and the right audience connections over time. This worksheet will help you craft a brand story that evolves and remains relevant.

Exercise

The 3-Part Brand Story Framework

01. The Catalyst (Why Your Brand Exists & Why It Matters)

Every brand starts because something needed to change. This isn't always a struggle — sometimes it's an opportunity no one else saw.

Example: Nike didn't start because Phil Knight wanted to be rich — it started because he saw a gap in performance shoes.

Ask Yourself:

- What needs to change?
- What do you see that others didn't?
- Why do you feel the need to act?

Your Answer:

02. The Core Truth (What Makes You Different & Why People Should Care)

A strong brand stands out — it doesn't blend in. Blending in leads to being forgotten. This doesn't mean being controversial for controversy's sake — it means having a core conviction that is different from the market and sharing that.

Example: The artist Russ believes that artists should own their music and stay independent to maintain creative control and be fairly paid. He reinforces this belief through his music and press interviews.

Ask Yourself:

- What do I believe that others don't?
- What about my personality stands out?
- What do people compliment me on that I can lean into?
- Why would the audience care about this?

Your Answer:

03. The Proof (How You Reinforce Your Identity Over Time)

A story isn't what you say — it's what you prove over and over again. Strong brands don't just have a past success story — they have an ongoing pattern of credibility.

Example: GaryVee didn't just talk about content volume once — he's proven it for 15+ years.

Ask Yourself:

- How does every piece of content reinforce the associations I want people to make with me?
- What case studies or examples can I share to establish credibility?
- If someone hears my name, what's the first thing I want them to think of?

Your Answer:

Caleb's Brand Story Using This Framework

..... **01** **02** **03**

The Catalyst

I saw brands scaling content views but struggling to build brand trust. The problem wasn't content—it was clarity on the big picture strategy.

The Core Truth

A strong brand is built by the intentional pairing of relevant things, done consistently—not just by going viral.

The Proof

I've built brands that scale businesses to many millions in revenue—and I show exactly how I do it, for free.



Build Your Brand Story in 3 Simple Steps

01

The Catalyst

What did you see that others didn't?

02

The Core Truth

What's the belief you have that others may not?

03

The Proof

How do you reinforce that identity every day, not only through statements but actions?

If you **nail these**, your brand won't just have a story—it'll have a **clear identity** that people **actually remember**.

03

Your Posting Cadence

Waterfall Distribution Method Playbook

Objective

The Waterfall Distribution Method is the most effective way to maximize content output and increase brand reach without reinventing the wheel. This strategy ensures that one piece of content fuels multiple platforms, making your content work harder for you. Originally popularized by GaryVee, this method has been refined over time into a repeatable system that turns a single high-value content piece into weeks of strategic distribution.

This playbook will guide you through:

1. **Identifying your pillar content** (the foundational piece that starts the process)
2. **Extracting micro-content** to repurpose for multiple platforms
3. **Breaking down formats** to match audience expectations
4. **Distributing strategically** to maximize engagement and reach

Step 01

Identify Your Pillar Content

Your pillar content is the foundation of your content strategy. It should be high-value, long-form, and packed with insights.

Examples of Pillar Content:

- A **YouTube long-form video** (12+ minutes with deep insights)
- A **high-value Twitter thread** that breaks down a concept
- A **newsletter issue** that teaches a framework
- A **long-form LinkedIn post** sharing detailed strategy
- A **podcast episode** featuring expert discussion

Key Question to Ask:

If my audience only consumed one piece of my content per week, what would I want it to be?

Your pillar content should be evergreen or highly relevant to your niche so that repurposing it over time still provides value.

Step 02

Extract Micro-Content (Mining for Gold)

Once you've created your pillar content, the next step is to break it down into smaller, digestible pieces for distribution across multiple platforms.

How to Find Micro-Content:

- **Identify the most valuable 30-60 second clips** from a long-form video or podcast
- **Pull out standout quotes** that could be shared as tweets or LinkedIn posts
- **Summarize the key takeaways** into a text-based format
- **Find controversial or contrarian takes** that could spark engagement

Step 03

Break Down Formats for Each Platform

Each platform has its own content style, audience behavior, and best practices. Your content should feel native to each platform while maintaining the core message.

Example Platform Breakdown:

- **YouTube Shorts, TikTok, Reels:** 30-120 second clips pulled from your long-form video
- **Twitter/X:** Break down insights into a thread (5-10 tweets max)
- **LinkedIn:** Turn the core idea into a written post or a carousel
- **Instagram Stories:** Share quick takeaways with engaging visuals
- **Email Newsletter:** Package insights from the original content into an email sequence

Step 04

Strategic Distribution Plan

To make this process efficient, systematize your workflow so that content is consistently distributed.

The Waterfall Process:

1. **Post your pillar content first** (YouTube, podcast, long-form post)
2. **Within 24-48 hours**, schedule micro-content across secondary platforms
3. **Engage & iterate** — monitor audience responses and double down on what's working
4. **Repurpose winners** — take high-performing content and find ways to expand on it

Pro Tip: Create a Content Calendar

Use a simple structure like:

Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Post pillar content	Twitter thread + LinkedIn post	Instagram carousel + YouTube short	TikTok/Reels video + second LinkedIn post	Email newsletter + engagement on platforms

Final Thoughts: Why This Works

The Waterfall Distribution Method ensures:

- You don't waste content — every piece has multiple uses
- You increase visibility — your audience sees your message multiple times in different formats
- You stay top of mind — repetition reinforces brand associations

If you execute this properly, one piece of content fuels an entire week (or more).



Action Step

Implement this system for your next content piece and track engagement across platforms. The more you refine this process, the more impact your brand will have.

Filming Environment Playbook

Objective

Create an efficient, repeatable system for filming high-quality content that ensures the best performance from both the talent and the production team. This playbook covers filming environments, talent management, follow-up questions, and overall best practices to optimize every shoot.

Step 01

Pre-Filming Preparation

Gear Checklist

Ensure all required equipment is packed and fully functional before arriving on set:

- ☐ **Camera body + Versatile lens** (Recommended: 24-70mm for flexibility)
- ☐ **SD Cards:**
 - ☐ Talking Head/Podcast: 1 TB SD Card (1x minimum)
 - ☐ Vlogging: 2 TB SD Card (2x -to avoid storage issues)
- ☐ **Batteries (Fully Charged!)**
 - ☐ Talking Head/Podcast: 3 Camera Batteries Minimum
 - ☐ Vlogging: 5 Camera Batteries Minimum
 - ☐ Lav Mic System (Transmitter & Receiver): 3+ Batteries Each
- ☐ **Tripod + Plate** (Ensure Attached to Camera Before Arriving)
- ☐ **In-ear Headphones** (for monitoring audio clarity)
- ☐ **Lav Mic System** (Receiver, Transmitter, Lav Mic)
- ☐ **Chargers** (If Filming for Extended Periods)

Pro Tip: Bring snacks, drinks, and small comfort items for the talent. Before filming, ask them what their go-to drink, snack, or essentials are (lip balm, nicotine gum, etc.). Small details build trust and improve performance.

Camera Settings

- ☐ **Frame Rate:** 24fps (for a cinematic look)
- ☐ **White Balance:** Auto (for vlogs), Manual (for controlled shoots)
- ☐ **Audio Levels:** Check lav mic clarity in headphones before filming starts
- ☐ **Image Stabilization:** Ensure it's enabled
- ☐ **Exposure:** Adjust per environment — never assume it's set correctly

Step 02

Filming Environment Optimization

Lighting

- **Indoor:** Position lights to remove harsh shadows; avoid overhead lighting unless diffused
- **Outdoor:** Aim for golden hour or overcast conditions. Direct sunlight can create harsh shadows
- **Consistency:** Maintain uniform lighting across shots for continuity

Audio

- **Lav Mic Positioning:** Attach securely, minimizing clothing rustle
- **Background Noise:** Avoid busy environments. Run a test recording before starting
- **Backup Audio:** If possible, record using two separate mic sources (lav + shotgun/boom mic)

Step 03

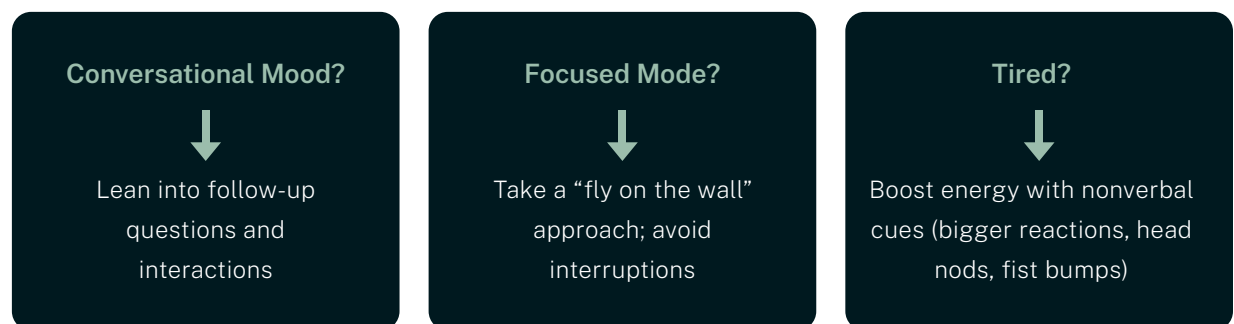
Talent Management & Maximizing Performance

First 5-10 Minutes: Setting the Tone

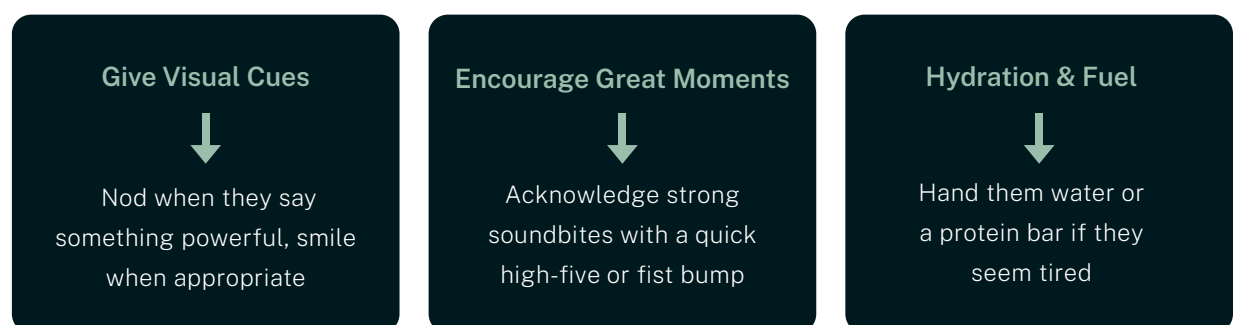
You dictate the energy of the filming day. **Be the thermostat**, not the *thermometer*.

- Walk in with positive energy
- Break tension by making a small joke, playful greeting, or lighthearted comment
- Pay attention to talent's energy level and mood (adjust accordingly)

Assess Talent's Energy:



Keeping Talent Engaged:



Step 04

Asking Follow-Up Questions for Deeper Content

How to Reverse-Engineer a Great Answer

01. Scenario

Talent says something insightful



Follow up to extract more depth

02. Example

Talent:

"I can't believe we finally closed that deal with the CEO. We've been trying for six months."

03. Follow-Up Strategy

01

Ask for Process Insights



"What do you think changed that made them finally say yes?"

02

Challenge Universality



"Would this approach work for any CEO, or was this specific to their company?"

03

Ask for Replicable Advice



"If someone wanted to achieve the same outcome, what's the biggest thing they should focus on?"

Another Example:

Talent in a meeting: *"I never make my top salesman the sales manager."*

Follow-ups:

"Why wouldn't your best salesperson make a great manager?"

"What are the three biggest skills that define a strong sales manager?"

Step 05

Filming Execution: Key Best Practices

Talking Head & Podcast Filming

- Start Both A & B Cameras at the Same Time
- Film in Chunks (record long takes, avoid frequent stopping)
- Capture Vertical Video on Phone (for repurposing into short-form content)

Vlogging Day

- Plan a Theme for the Day (Have 3-5 questions to shape the episode)
- Keep Rolling During Key Events (longer, unbroken takes = better edits)
- Pay Attention to Candid Moments (some of the best content is unscripted)

Post-Filming: Maximizing Impact

Immediate Follow-Up

- Give Talent a High Five/Fist Bump and mention 2-3 highlights from the shoot
- Reinforce Positive Associations → “Today’s shoot was 🔥. That segment on X is going to resonate HARD with the audience.”

File Management & Backup

- Ingest Footage Immediately → Copy files to hard drive + cloud storage
- Send Talent a Quick Thank You Message
- Post in Team Chat → Summarize key footage + upload locations
- Charge All Batteries for Next Shoot

Final Pro Tip: Build Talent Trust

The more the talent trusts the filming process, the better their performance. Make every filming session positive, easy, and seamless. The more they enjoy the process, the better content you’ll get.

Conclusion

This playbook ensures that every film session is efficient, professional, and delivers maximum value. By optimizing filming environments, keeping talent engaged, and using powerful follow-up questioning, you can consistently create high-impact, engaging content.

Implement these best practices and watch your filming sessions become smoother, more productive, and higher quality than ever before.

Ralston Select

If all of this feels overwhelming, or you're clear on the strategy but unsure how to implement it, that's exactly why we created **Ralston Select**. It's built for the team supporting your personal brand, not just the person on camera, and it's our most accessible offer yet.

This is about making content to get customers, not just rack up views. **Here's Everything You Get With Ralston Select:**



Monthly Live Feedback & Training

Monthly 60+ min live group session led by Caleb Ralston's Content Director, Trevor Odom. Real content reviewed, refined, and improved.



Full In-Depth Curriculum

The most in-depth training on Pre-Production, Production, Post Production, and Platform Strategy for educational content.



Quarterly Sessions with Top Leaders

Behind-the-scenes strategy from people doing this at scale. Not the faces of the brands you see though, the people in the trenches.



Monthly "Ask Trevor Anything"

Monthly 2 hour AMA with Ralston's Content Director, Trevor Odom. Bring real questions and get real time tactical answers.

[CLICK HERE FOR MORE INFORMATION](#)

04

Storytelling in Your Content

Storytelling Playbook

Objective

Storytelling isn't just a creative tool — it's a strategic weapon. In a world where attention is the most valuable currency, stories keep people hooked and create emotional connections that make your brand memorable. People don't remember facts — they remember how you made them feel.

This playbook will break down:

1. The structure of a compelling story
2. The best types of stories to tell
3. How to weave storytelling into different content formats

Step 01

The Structure of a Compelling Story

The best stories follow a clear framework to capture attention, build engagement, and drive action.

01. The Hook (Get Attention Fast)

Online, you have 2 seconds to grab attention. Start with a bold statement, a problem, or a question.

Examples:

"I almost ruined my career in 2018 because of one mistake..."
"Are you tired of posting the same shit that never works?"

02. The Problem (Set Up the Stakes)

Conflict and tension make stories engaging. The problem should be specific and relatable to your audience.

Example:

"I was working 14-hour days editing videos for GaryVee, but I still felt stuck..."

03. The Journey (How You Overcame It)

People resonate with progress, not perfection. Show the messy middle—the doubts, the failures, and the "almost quitting" moment.

Example:

"I realized I was burning out because I was trying to do everything myself. That's when I made this shift..."

04. The Lesson (Make It Useful)

Every story should end with a clear takeaway. The lesson should tie back to your expertise and provide value.

Example:

"Here's what I learned, and here's how you can apply it."

05. The CTA (Turn Story into Action)

Close with a simple, natural next step. ————— **Examples:**

"If you're struggling with X, try Y today."

Step 02

The Best Types of Stories to Tell

Not all stories work equally well in content. The best ones fall into these categories:

01. Origin Stories (Why You Started)

Why do you do what you do? What pivotal moment shaped your career? ————— **Examples:**

"I read Crush It! at 15 and knew I had to be in content creation."

02. Failure Stories (Relatability & Trust)

People trust vulnerability more than success. Talk about what went wrong and what you learned. ————— **Example:**

"I lost my biggest client because I didn't understand this one thing..."

03. Success Stories (Teach Through Proof)

Show before & after transformations. Highlight small wins that led to big results. ————— **Example:**

"How I took GaryVee's TikTok from 300K to 3.5M in 3 months."

04. Customer/Client Stories (Social Proof)

Let your audience see themselves in your content. ————— **Example:**

"One of my coaching clients went from 0 to 100K followers in 90 days by using this strategy..."

05. Industry Stories (Position Yourself as a Thought Leader)

Talk about trends, mistakes, and shifts in your industry. ————— **Example:**

"The way brands create content is changing — here's what no one is talking about..."

Final Thoughts: Why Storytelling Works

Stories grab attention and hold it. Stories create an emotional connection that makes people remember you. Stories make your content more engaging, shareable, and impactful.

Start integrating stories into your content today, and watch how it **transforms** your **brand presence** and **audience engagement**.

05

Create Space for Experimentation

Content Hackathon Playbook

Objective

A **Content Hackathon** is a dedicated day each quarter (or month) for the team to break out of routine content production and create entirely new formats and styles that wouldn't normally be produced. This practice fosters creativity, experimentation, and innovation, allowing the team to push creative limits and develop content that could become a new brand standard.

Step 01

Purpose & Notification

Advance Planning & Communication

- Announce the Content Hackathon at least one month in advance so the team can plan accordingly
- Managers should work closely with their direct reports to ensure all regular tasks and deadlines are completed beforehand, allowing the entire team to dedicate their full energy to the hackathon
- Make it clear that this day is fully blocked off for experimentation—no meetings, no client calls, no distractions

Step 02

Hackathon Schedule & Structure

Kickoff Meeting (9:00 - 9:15 AM)

- Set the tone: Emphasize that the focus is on creating content the team has never done before — this is about innovation, not just production
- Go over the rules and expectations:

No “safe” ideas — push boundaries.

Aim for one, max two pieces, per person

Be prepared to present and explain creative choices.

Creation Period (9:15 AM - 4:00 PM)

- The team works on developing innovative content based on new formats, styles, or approaches
- Encourage team members to take big creative swings—the goal is to experiment with what could work, not just what has worked before

Step 03

Upload & Presentation

Content Upload (4:00 PM - 4:15 PM)

- Each participant uploads their work to a shared Google Slide deck, ensuring that every submission has a dedicated slide with the final content piece (or a preview if it's video-based)

Content Upload (4:00 PM - 4:15 PM)

- Each team member presents their work, explaining:
 - Why they chose their concept
 - What they were trying to accomplish
 - What worked and what they would improve

- Encourage an open discussion about what content styles should be explored further in future production cycles

Step 04

Voting & Incentive

Anonymous Voting Process

- Conduct an anonymous team vote to determine the most innovative piece of content
- Use a fair and transparent method like Google Forms, Slido, or another polling tool
- Voting criteria:
 1. Creativity – Is this a fresh approach?
 2. Potential Impact – Could this be a game-changing content format?
 3. Brand Fit – While pushing boundaries, does it still align with the brand's identity?

Winner Incentives

- The winner receives a reward, such as an Amazon gift card, team recognition, or an opportunity to develop their idea into a full-scale campaign
- The real incentive: the winning content (and other top pieces) will be tested in actual distribution – turning experiments into real-world impact

Step 04

Follow-Up & Implementation

Scheduling & Testing

- Work with channel managers to strategically schedule and test the hackathon content
- Determine which pieces will be published and track their performance

Analysis & Learnings

- Review engagement, reach, and audience reactions
- Identify what worked and why, and refine the best ideas for future content strategies

Final Thoughts: Why This Works

- Encourages Creative Risks** → Forces the team to step outside their comfort zone
- Breaks Content Stagnation** → Injects new ideas into the pipeline
- Turns Experimentation Into Real-World Impact** → Winning ideas don't just stay in the hackathon; they get tested and iterated
- Builds a Culture of Innovation** → The team gets excited about pushing creative limits regularly



Action Step

Plan your next Content Hackathon, set clear expectations, and absolutely crush that shit.

06

Streamline Your Hiring Process

Job Description Worksheet

Objective

A solid job description isn't just a list of tasks—it's a magnet for the right talent. If you're not crystal clear on what you need, you'll attract people who aren't the right fit. This worksheet will help you write a clear, compelling, and effective job description by breaking down what to include, why it matters, and how to make it stand out. You'll get a section-by-section breakdown, fill-in-the-blank template, and a real example so you're not guessing. The goal? To make sure the right person reads this and immediately knows, *"This is for me."*

Job Description Sections & What They Mean

Role

A couple sentences that sum up what this position is and why it exists; think of it as the job's purpose in a sentence

Responsibilities

A clear, no-fluff list of what this person will actually do day-to-day; this helps them visualize the role and understand what's expected

Requirements

The non-negotiables—skills, experience, or traits someone must have to be successful in this role; keep it focused on what truly matters

Results

What success looks like in this role. Instead of just listing tasks, this section defines what the outcome should be

Availability

The days/times you expect them to work; be upfront about schedule expectations to avoid misalignment later

Compensation Range

A transparent salary or pay range so candidates know what to expect before applying

Company Core Values

What your company stands for and how you operate; this isn't just fluff—values determine culture fit, so it's crucial to include

Role	
Responsibilities	
Requirements	
Results	
Availability	
Compensation Range	
Company Core Values	

Below is a real job description that has been anonymized.

Brand Director, _____'s Personal Brand

Location: _____

Department: Marketing

Reports To: Chief Executive Officer

Compensation: \$245,000 + Performance Bonus

Role Overview

_____ is looking for a Brand Director to build and scale CEO _____'s personal brand across YouTube, LinkedIn, and other key platforms. This role requires a deep understanding of content strategy, social media growth, and personal brand development. You will be responsible for transforming _____'s thought leadership into an influential digital presence that resonates with entrepreneurs, business leaders, and innovators.

Responsibilities

Content Strategy & Execution

- Establish and scale _____'s YouTube presence, leveraging his speeches and interviews to create both long-form and short-form content.
 - Eventually building on top of this and developing platform native, platform first YouTube content.
- Develop and execute a LinkedIn content strategy, incorporating a mix of written posts and short-form videos derived from existing content.
- Identify key content themes and topics that align with _____'s expertise, industry trends, and audience interests.
- Continuously refine content distribution strategies to maximize engagement and growth.

Content Strategy & Execution

- Oversee the filming and editing process for social content, ensuring high-quality production and platform-specific optimization.
- Work closely with editors, writers, and content strategists to develop engaging assets tailored

for each platform.

- Conduct biweekly interviews with _____' to extract valuable insights for LinkedIn content.
- Oversee and direct post-production workflows to ensure fast execution and high-impact creative.

Team Building & Leadership

- Develop a roadmap for scaling the personal brand team, hiring creatives, editors, and strategists as needed. Some full time in house, some freelance.
 - Explore utilization of the current creative team first.
- Manage external creative partners and agencies where necessary, ensuring alignment with brand goals.
- Provide creative direction to the team, ensuring a consistent and compelling brand voice.

Platform Strategy & Growth

- Stay ahead of social media trends and platform algorithm changes to ensure _____'s brand is optimized for maximum reach and engagement.
- Develop a strategy to evolve and adapt as social platforms and audience behaviors shift.
- Analyze content performance metrics and iterate based on data-driven insights.

Requirements

- 3+ years of experience growing a personal brand with proven success in scaling reach and engagement.
- Expertise in social media content strategy, and understanding the nuance in strategy between long form video, short form video, podcast, and written.
- Strong background in filming, editing, and social content production (both short-form and long-form).
- Deep understanding of social platform algorithms, engagement tactics, and audience growth strategies.
- Experience managing creatives
- Exceptional storytelling skills, with the ability to extract and refine high-value insights.
- A passion for entrepreneurship, business growth, and thought leadership content.
- Based in _____ or willing to relocate.

Results (KPIs & Success Metrics)

- Establish _____'s YouTube channel with consistent long-form uploads and high-performing clips.
- Scale LinkedIn engagement and follower growth through a mix of written and video content.
- Increase overall brand awareness and _____'s positioning as a thought leader in business and technology.
- Build a scalable content team to support the long-term vision of the brand.
- Drive measurable audience growth and engagement across platforms.
- Weekly reporting on content performance and audience growth.

Communication Expectations & Availability

- Availability: Monday – Friday 8am – 6pm
- With occasional weekend work

Communication Expectations & Availability

- *Core values can go here*

07

Hiring Process

Hiring Funnel Playbook

Objective

Most hiring advice is outdated and built for slow-moving companies — not for brands that need fast, creative, high-impact teams. The Hiring Playbook is designed to help you find, vet, and build a team that actually delivers — people who move fast, think ahead, and make your life easier, not harder.

This playbook isn't about guessing. It's built on first principles — from defining the right roles to filtering for the right people, onboarding them effectively, and keeping A-players engaged. Follow this framework, and you won't just hire — you'll build a team that scales your brand the right way.

Step 01

The Hiring Mindset

Your Team = Your Multiplier

- The right hires don't just execute — they amplify everything you do. If you're trying to scale, your team needs to move at your speed.

Hire for Culture, Train for Skills

- You can teach someone technical skills. Tougher to teach drive, empathy, adaptability, or the ability to think three steps ahead.

Find People Who Are Deep in Their Lane but Can Play Multiple Positions

- Early hires should be specialists who don't mind wearing different hats. Later, you can niche them down.

Step 02

Get Clear on What You Actually Need

Where Are You the Bottleneck?

- If content slows down every time after you film, your first hire should be an editor. If growth is your focus, bring in a strategist before more creatives.

Prioritize by Platform & Impact

- Example: If YouTube is driving business, you need an editor who understands retention and pacing — not just someone who knows how to cut clips.

Find People Who Are Deep in Their Lane but Can Play Multiple Positions

- Early hires should be specialists who don't mind wearing different hats. Later, you can niche them down.

Step 03

The Hiring Funnel (No Random Resumes Allowed)

Every hire should go through these steps before they join your team:

01. Define the Role Clearly

- Are they creating, managing, or analyzing content?
- What does success look like for them in 3-6 months?
- Keep it simple: If you can't describe their role in a sentence, it's not clear enough.

02. The Filter Process

- **Resume Submission**
 - (Optional) Have them submit a video application explaining why they want this role.
- **Screening Call**
 - Quick convo to make sure expectations align (pay, workload, remote vs. in-person).
- **Technical Interview + Skill Test (No Hypotheticals, Real Work)**
 - Ask them the "nitty gritty" questions that prove they are technically proficient (this is ideally conducted by an SME or someone with enough context to ask technical questions)
 - If they pass the technical interview, give them a task that mirrors the actual job. Example: If hiring a short-form editor, send them raw footage and see how they structure it.
- **Culture Fit Interview**
 - This is where you find out if they're someone you want to work with every day.
- **Final Interview (Leadership Sign-Off)**
 - If they've made it this far, this is more about getting them hyped and aligned.

Pro Tip: If you're strapped for time, combine steps instead of skipping them.

Step 04

Onboarding: Setting the Tone from Day One

30/60/90-Day Roadmap

- Make sure they know what "winning" looks like in the first three months.

Let Them Take Ownership

- Set clear expectations, but don't micromanage. Instead of fixing their mistakes, ask: *"How would you handle this?"*

Make Speed a Habit

- Fast execution beats perfect execution. Get them comfortable making decisions quickly.

Step 05

Scaling the Team (Without Breaking It)

Start Lean, Then Specialize

- The first people you hire will be specialists forced to be generalists.
- Over time, refine their roles based on strengths and impact.

Don't Scale Chaos

- If your systems are a mess, more people won't fix it — they'll just make it worse. Nail your processes before you add bodies.

Step 06

Leadership & Retention

Help People Go Deep in Their Skillset

- Encourage your team to master one area instead of half-assing five.

Create an Environment Where They Want to Stay

- Pay well, challenge them, and make sure they feel like they're growing.
- A-Players won't stick around if they're not growing.

Keep It Fun

- Experiment. Do content hackathons. Let people try weird ideas. The best content comes from teams that actually enjoy what they do.

Final Thought

Hiring isn't about filling roles—it's about building momentum and solving problems. A great team doesn't just execute your vision; they push it forward.

Follow this, and you'll build a squad that can scale your brand the right way.

Now go find your A-players.

08

Full-Time Employees vs Contractors & Agencies

Full-Time Employees vs Contractors & Agencies Worksheet

Objective

Use this worksheet to determine the best hiring option based on your business needs, workload, budget, and required expertise. Answer the questions below and use the decision-making table to evaluate your options.

Step 01

Identify Your Needs

Hiring Decision Formula

Use the table below to calculate the best hiring option based on your specific needs. Assign values (1-5) to each criterion where 1 = Not Important and 5 = Critical. Then total the scores for each column.

Criteria	Full-Time	Contractor	Agency
Ongoing, long-term need			
Requires niche expertise			
High flexibility needed			
Budget for salary & benefits			
Quick execution required			
Company culture integration			
Scalability needed			
Specialized, multi-skill team			
Low overhead costs preferred			
Speed to hire			
Total Score			

Decision Guide

- Highest Score = Recommended Option
- Full-Time Employee → Best for ongoing, stable roles with deep integration.
- Contractor → Best for flexible, specialized, and short-term needs.
- Agency → Best for scalable, high-expertise, multi-disciplinary projects.

Step 02

Next Steps & Action Items

If Hiring a Full-Time Employee:

- Write a detailed job description outlining responsibilities, qualifications, and growth potential.
- Allocate budget for salary, benefits, and onboarding.
- Develop a structured hiring process (job posting, screening, interviews, trial period).
- Plan for long-term career growth and retention strategies.

If Hiring a Contractor:

- Write a detailed job description outlining responsibilities, qualifications, and growth potential.
- Allocate budget for salary, benefits, and onboarding.
- Develop a structured hiring process (job posting, screening, interviews, trial period).
- Plan for long-term career growth and retention strategies.

If Hiring an Agency:

- Research agencies with a strong track record in your industry.
- Evaluate portfolios, client reviews, and past case studies.
- Define success metrics, deliverables, and expected ROI.
- Establish clear communication and approval processes for projects.

Final Thought: Avoid Hiring Pitfalls

Don't hire out of panic → Rushed hiring decisions often lead to misalignment and wasted resources

Prioritize cultural fit for full-time roles → Skills can be trained, but alignment with company values is harder to develop

Start with a trial project for contractors and agencies → This minimizes risk and ensures alignment before deeper engagement

Regularly reassess needs → Your business will evolve — make sure your hiring decisions stay aligned with long-term goals

09

Onboard Your Team Effectively

30/60/90 Day Onboarding Worksheet

Objective

A strong 30/60/90-day onboarding plan sets new employees up for success by giving them a clear roadmap for what to focus on, how to integrate into the team, and what success looks like at each stage. This worksheet will help you structure an effective plan that ensures your new hire gains momentum quickly and delivers impact.

Instructions

- Use this worksheet to map out key milestones, goals, and expectations for the first 90 days
- Each section should have clear learning objectives, tasks, and measurable outcomes
- The goal is to transition the new hire from learning → contributing → owning their role

30/60/90 Day Plan Template

30 Days – Learning & Immersion

Focus: Understanding the company, role, expectations, and workflow.

Key Learning Objectives:

Tasks & Deliverables:

Success Metrics:

60 Days – Contribution & Execution

Focus: Applying knowledge, taking on responsibilities, and delivering early wins.

Key Learning Objectives:

Tasks & Deliverables:

Success Metrics:

90 Days – Ownership & Impact

Focus: Fully owning the role, driving initiatives, and making a measurable impact.

Key Learning Objectives:

Tasks & Deliverables:

Success Metrics:

Final Step: Review & Feedback

- At the end of each phase (30, 60, 90 days), have a check-in meeting to review progress and adjust goals if needed.
- Gather feedback from the new hire on their experience and areas for improvement.
- Ensure the employee has a clear roadmap for continued growth and success beyond 90 days.



Action Step

Use this template to build a custom onboarding plan for your next new hire and ensure they hit the ground running.

10

Develop & Retain Your High Performing Team

Effective 1:1 Playbook

Objective

1:1 meetings aren't just check-ins — they're a high-leverage tool for developing your team, solving roadblocks, and keeping communication clear. Done right, they build trust, improve performance, and ensure everyone's on the same page with the company goals. This playbook will walk you through how to structure and run effective 1:1s that drive real impact.

1:1 Meeting Framework

Part 01

Frequency & Duration

01

Cadence



Weekly or bi-weekly
(based on team size
and role complexity)

02

Length



30-45 minutes max — long
enough to dive deep, but
not waste time

03

Format



Can be in-person, via
video call, or phone, but
should be consistent.

Part 02

Meeting Structure

A good 1:1 should be structured yet flexible, ensuring key topics are covered while leaving room for open discussion.

Core Agenda (Simple, Repeatable Format)

Wins & Highlights (5 min)

- What's going well? Celebrate progress and achievements.
- Recognize effort and reinforce positive behaviors.

Challenges & Roadblocks (10 min)

- What's slowing you down or frustrating you?
- How can I help remove obstacles or provide support?

Priorities & Goals (10 min)

- Are you clear on what to focus on this week/month?
- Are there any adjustments needed to hit key objectives?

Feedback (5-10 min)

- Manager gives actionable feedback (specific, timely, and clear).
- Employee shares feedback on what's working or areas to improve.

Growth & Development (Optional, but crucial for long-term success)

- What skills do you want to develop?
- How can I support your career progression?

Part 03

Key Principles for Effective 1:1s

Be Present & Engaged

No multitasking, Slack messages, or distractions. This is dedicated time for your team members.

Listen More Than You Talk

Aim for 80% listening, 20% talking. Let them drive the conversation.

Ask Open-Ended Questions

Example: "What's one thing I can do better to support you?"

Follow Up on Action Items

If something is discussed, track it and follow up the next time you meet.

Make It About Them

This isn't just a status update — it's about supporting their success and growth.

Common Mistakes & How to Avoid Them

Turning 1:1s into Status Updates: Use async tools (Slack, Notion) for routine updates; keep 1:1s focused on real discussions.

Skipping or Constantly Rescheduling : Sends a message that their development isn't a priority. Make 1:1s non-negotiable.

Only Giving Feedback When Something's Wrong : Regular feedback builds trust & prevents bigger issues down the road.

Being Too Generic: "*How's everything going?*" won't spark real conversations. Use targeted questions.

[Employee Name] 1:1 Meeting Notes

A good 1:1 should be structured yet flexible, ensuring key topics are covered while leaving room for open discussion.

Date: _____

Key Wins & Progress:

Challenges & Roadblocks:

Priorities & Goals:

Feedback & Action Items:

Career Growth & Development (Optional):

Follow-Up Items for Next Meeting:

Why This Works

**Keeps communication
clear & proactive**



Prevents misalignment and surprises

Strengthens trust & retention



Employees who feel heard and supported stay longer

**Creates a culture of
continuous improvement**



Regular feedback and goal-setting drive performance



Action Step

Implement this playbook in your next 1:1 and refine based on what works best for your team.

11

Build A Strong Team Culture

Maker vs Manager Schedule Playbook

Objective

To optimize efficiency and creativity in media teams by implementing a structured schedule that protects deep work for creators (makers) while allowing managers to effectively handle meetings and operations.

The Playbook

Part 01

Understanding the Maker vs. Manager Dynamic

Makers

(editors, designers, writers, strategists)

Need uninterrupted blocks of time to enter a flow state and produce high-quality work.

Managers

(team leads, producers, project managers)

Rely on meetings and real-time collaboration to push projects forward.

The conflict arises when managers schedule meetings in a way that disrupts makers' deep work, causing context-switching delays that reduce efficiency.

Part 02

Structuring the Workday

To balance both needs, implement a **split schedule**:

Morning: Maker Time (7 AM - 12 PM)

- Blocked for deep work, no meetings unless absolutely critical.
- Writers script, editors cut, designers design — without interruptions.
- Managers should avoid pulling makers into meetings during this time.

Afternoon: Manager Time (12 PM - 5 PM)

- Reserved for meetings, strategy sessions, team check-ins, and collaborative work.
- Creatives who need to meet with others can schedule calls during this window.

Part 03

Weekly Workflow Optimization

Monday = Manager Day

- Stack as many meetings as possible on this day to minimize disruptions the rest of the week.

Tuesday & Thursday = Hybrid Days

- Mornings are for making, afternoons for necessary check-ins.

Wednesday = Maker Day

- No meetings. Full deep-work day.
- Encourage the team to push creative boundaries and experiment with new formats.

Friday = Flex Maker Day

- Primarily a maker day, but with flexibility for urgent meetings if needed.
- Ideal for finalizing edits, polishing content, and planning for the next week.

Part 04

Implementation & Best Practices

Use Calendar Blocks

Have team members mark their Maker Time as “Do Not Disturb” on their calendars.

Enforce the Structure

Managers must respect deep work periods and avoid last-minute meeting requests.

Set Expectations with Clients & Stakeholders

Example: “What’s one thing I can do better to support you?”

Review & Adjust

Gather feedback from the team regularly and refine the schedule as needed.

Conclusion

Implementing a Maker vs. Manager schedule dramatically increases efficiency, reduces burnout, and enhances creativity within media teams. By protecting deep work time, your editors, writers, and designers can deliver better content faster, while managers maintain the strategic oversight they need to keep things running smoothly.

Remote vs In-Person vs Hybrid Worksheet

Objective

This worksheet is designed to help teams determine the best work model — Remote, In-Person, or Hybrid — by evaluating key factors such as flexibility, collaboration, productivity, cost, talent pool, culture, and security needs. By circling responses that best reflect their team's requirements, users can easily identify the ideal work setup that aligns with their goals and operational needs.

Instructions

For each question, circle the answer that best describes your team's needs. Each circle counts as 1 point. At the end, tally up your points in each column — the column with the most points is your best-fit work model.

Question	Remote	In-Person	Hybrid
How important is flexibility for your team?	We need full freedom to work from anywhere	We thrive on fixed schedules and office presence	A mix of office and remote would work
How does your team collaborate best?	Through digital tools and async communication	In person with real-time discussions	A mix of structured in-office and remote work
What best describes your productivity needs?	Focused, independent work with minimal distractions	Structured work with in-person accountability	A mix of deep work and collaborative sessions
What's your budget for office space?	We want to save on costs	We're okay with higher office expenses	We need a balance — some office space but lower overhead
How important is hiring from a global talent pool?	Very important (Access to the best talent anywhere)	Not important (We prefer hiring locally)	Somewhat important (We need a mix of local and remote talent)
How do you build company culture?	Through virtual engagement and team-building activities	Through in-person bonding and shared experiences	A combination of remote and in-office culture-building
What are your security and IT needs?	We're okay with investing in remote security solutions	We need a controlled, in-office IT infrastructure	A mix of remote security and in-office IT support

End with this.

If you made it this far, first of all — respect. Most people don't take the time to work through something like this, and that's exactly why most people never build a real brand.

Now, here's the deal: This is just the beginning. The strategies and frameworks in this workbook will only work if you apply them, iterate, and keep executing.

Shoot me a DM on IG. I'd love to hear how this is going for you. Keep me posted on your progress, your wins, and even the challenges you're running into.

If you have questions that came up after going through the course and workbook, join my Town Hall (calebralston.com/townhall), where we dive deeper into brand building and answer real questions from people actually doing the work.

Appreciate you. Now go build a brand you're proud of.





